Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra are doing a few rallies, the burden of the battle rests squarely on Tejashwi's shoulders. With Lalu sidelined by age and illness, every microphone, slogan and headline must amplify Tejashwi's voice. While the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) flaunts its collective power and administrative continuity, the MGB alliance answers with one man's self-belief and drive. In 2025, it is unmistakably Tejashwi versus the NDA.

TURNING OF THE TIDE

Just days earlier, the MGB poll campaign in Bihar had looked rudderless, squabbling over seats, with major partners refusing to see the big picture. That changed on October 23 with the Congress stepping off its high horse and greenlighting the formal declaration of Tejashwi as MGB's CM candidate, leading the alliance into battle against an entrenched incumbent, the NDA government led by the Bharatiya Janata Party and the Janata Dal (United). That decision gave the faltering MGB the momentum it needed. Tejashwi now fights his toughest battle, but it's his best chance yet—the closest he's ever been to winning. He also exhibits the vigour of a man still running only his second full race, and seems at his most mature ever.

A tangible epitome of that is his many-hued chariot, the MGB. At a recent press conference, he projected a tableau of inclusivity, flanked by Mallah leader and newly anointed deputy CM candidate, Mukesh Sahani of the Vikassheel Insaan party (VIP), and a Dalit face from the RJD, ex-minister Shiv Chandra Ram. He knows that in a straight fight against the NDA, stitching together the more colourful rainbow coalition of castes could decide the outcome. Hence his announcement of "a one-time, interest-free financial assistance of Rs 5 lakh for traditional working-class communities such as barbers, potters, carpenters and blacksmiths, to help them achieve economic upliftment and self-employment". It was a social and electoral manoeuvre aimed at bringing an additional five per cent votes into the MGB kitty. According to the Bihar caste survey, barbers account for 1.6 per cent of Bihar's roughly 130 million population, carpenters 1.5 per cent, potters 1.4 per cent and blacksmiths 0.6 per cent—small groups, but significant in a state where wafer-thin margins often decide political destinies. Shiv Chandra and Congress's Bihar president Rajesh Ram, both of whom are Ravidasi Dalits (5 per cent of the population) should also exert a major influence on that community's vote. There is also the Left's vote to consider; the CPI(ML), especially, has an extremely loyal base among its disempowered cohorts.

Having missed the chief minister's chair in 2020 by just 12 seats, or 12,000 votes (with a respective vote share of 37.23 and 37.26 per cent, the difference between the



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Cognisant of Tejashwi's efforts to broadbase his support, PM Modi launched the NDA campaign from Samastipur, home district of EBC icon Karpoori Thakur

MGB and NDA was a minuscule 0.03 per cent), Tejashwi now appears to have taken a methodical approach that covers all bases and expects to make the lantern glow in corners of Bihar where it has long flickered but rarely burned bright. Bihar's EBCs (nearly 36 per cent of the population) and Dalits (19.6 per cent) hold the key to power. Not only has Tejashwi stitched up a caste coalition that goes beyond the RJD's core 32 per cent M-Y cohort (17.7 per cent Muslim and 14.3 per cent Yadav), he has also upended the campaign narrative in other ways. He has made jobs—or specifically the promise of one government job per every family in Bihar—central to every poll-related conversation in the state, and also extended welfare benefits to contractual government employees while doubling honorariums for panchayat and kachahri members. An MGB poll promise that may aid the cause is the review of prohibition. Some 85 per cent of the 1.27 million jailed in liquor cases are from the Dalit/EBC/OBC category and the manifesto promises them 'immediate relief'.

Women are the other crucial vote bank in Bihar, and have been the mainstay of Nitish's victories. The RJD is fielding 23 women candidates this time (the most among